Chapter 36

Freedom from Sabotage: Shaking Off the Shackles

THE DATE: 25 JULY 2007. ON THIS DAY, A WOMAN (PRATIBHA PATIL) was being sworn in as the president of India for the first time since independence. On the same day Delhi, the capital of the country, too could have had its first woman police commissioner, but that was not to be. The 'appointers' used their positions of responsibility not only for keeping me out of the top slot but also for fulfilling their own personal agendas.

In this chapter, I have put forward my candid and considered views as to why I believe I was deprived of the ultimate responsibility and how a certain coterie of bureaucrats along with members of my own service sabotaged my return to Delhi Police, which was home to me. They did not allow me to serve the city of Delhi in a manner that would have set new trends in police– public partnership. The coterie knew that I would go all out for changes, which they never wanted as they themselves never brought them about. How could they permit me to create an island of police reform in the country? And how could they explain the immediate past? The Delhi Police bastion had to be protected and sealed. It was a question of sheer survival for some as they feared that in case I occupied the top post many of their ways of functioning would be known!

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I had firmed up in my mind and clearly indicated to the appointing 'controllers' (political and bureaucratic) that I would move out in case I was overlooked for the police commissionership of Delhi. Hence, the coterie knew about my decision, and I could see the dithering in their decision making. It was evident in the granting of extensions to the entrenched incumbent for no specific reason except for the fact that they wanted to delay my return to the extent possible, since I was next in line, both in rank and seniority. And they were also apprehensive of the public backlash in case they ignored me. Or else how does one explain the UN selection (see Chapter 33)? What mattered most to the coterie, I believe, was having their 'man' in place and capping the past.

I was almost asleep when the post-dinner, delayed announcement of the new police commissioner started to come on the TV channels. As soon as my god-daughter, Neetu, saw this, she came to my bedside and shook me awake, without knowing perhaps how to break the news. She only said: 'Mamu (as she calls me), watch the news. It's about the police commissioner's appointment.' I suddenly raised my head from the pillow to look at the TV in my room. I saw the ticker and the first thought that flashed across my mind was: 'Oh God, finally.' I told Neetu: 'I have been set free' (free from sleeping with my boots on for the next two years). I went back to sleep.

The next morning, as I got up to go for my morning walk, I was told that the exit door of my house was jammed with media persons. I met them and expressed my feelings of anguish, loss and relief at